



Skewed rivalry: India meets Pakistan in Colombo in a rivalry reshaped by recent results, batting depth and the memory of past World Cup upsets. AP

>> India vs Pakistan, Colombo

Against the backdrop of renewed geopolitical tensions and a bitterly contested Asia Cup last year, the neighbours will renew their rivalry on the neutral shores of Colombo in the tournament's top billing. While India's recent domination of Pakistan, including a 3-0 sweep in the Asia Cup, points towards a skewed rivalry, one that skipper Suryakumar Yadav even dismissed nonchalantly, the T20 World Cup stage is known for upsets. Pakistan's 10-wicket drubbing of India at the 2021 showpiece will keep the Men in Blue from slipping into complacency. However, this is a vastly transformed Indian team, constantly pushing the boundaries of what is possible in the shortest version of the sport. Abhishek Sharma, the world's best T20I batter, has made it customary to hit the first ball of the innings out of the park, and his face-off against Shaheen Shah Afridi, which saw a tense prelude during the Asia Cup, will be tantalising. An in-form Suryakumar Yadav and India's marauding middle order will be tough to contain for Pakistan's spinners. Their world-class Indian counterparts, meanwhile, had ripped through Pakistan in the continental event in Dubai, and a repeat could be on the cards. Matching India's batting firepower will be a challenge, but Pakistan can turn to Sahibzada Farhan, though Jasprit Bumrah may not let him off easily this time around. The individual subplots will inevitably feed into the larger conflict, so do not expect friendly fire.